

Generation-Defining Design

Principles for Shivaliva Shanty

Adapted from “We Need A New Minecraft” (Internet Intellectuals). A reference for Claude Code: the timeless-game principles from the video, translated for this project — with honest notes on where they fit and where they don’t.

HOW TO USE THIS DOC: Treat these as aspirations, not hard constraints (those live in the Community Research doc and the Project Handoff). The goal: build something with a low skill floor, a high ceiling, and a soul players remember. Read Section 5 carefully — it flags where Minecraft’s lessons need adapting for a structured puzzle-skill game rather than a sandbox.

1. Nostalgia Through Audio & Simplicity

Music as emotional memory

A game’s music shouldn’t be background noise — it should evoke emotion that deepens over time. If the soundtrack is evocative, players will recall the exact feeling of playing years later.

- **For Shivaliva Shanty:** This is a natural strength. Sea-shanties and per-location ambient themes are core to the Puzzle Pirates DNA. Commission or generate distinct, memorable music per location and per puzzle — the Cradle Rock hub theme should feel like home.

Simplicity as strength

Don’t overcomplicate. The initial magic relies on simplicity — a simple framework lets players project their own fun onto the game rather than only consuming pre-made content.

- **For Shivaliva Shanty:** Each parlor game should be graspable in seconds. The core loop — do a puzzle, run the ship — stays clean. Resist piling on systems before the core is proven fun.

2. Design for Unconstrained Creativity

The most engaged players have no artificial limits on creativity except those in their own minds. Give players tools to do chaotic, seemingly pointless things just to “see what happens.” Avoid rigid loops: offer a world that can technically be beaten quickly but keeps players returning because it’s a canvas for their own ideas.

Masterpieces like Red Dead Redemption 2 or Dark Souls are heavily structured. A generation-defining game keeps players coming back as a canvas, not a corridor.

Honest note for this project: Shivaliva Shanty is a structured, single-player-first puzzle-skill game (puzzle loops, job chains, voyages, a mastery ladder), NOT a pure sandbox. Full “unconstrained creativity” conflicts with that. Adapt the spirit, not the letter — see Section 5.

3. Structural Criteria for a Timeless Game

The video’s checklist for an era-defining game:

1. **Rated below Teen.** Accessible to kids, families, and adults — maximizes the player base and lets it become a childhood staple.

2. **Affordable.** Keep the barrier to entry low.
3. **Not strictly story-driven.** Linear stories expire once completed; aim for infinite replayability.
4. **Indie-designed.** Big corporations prioritize monetization over gameplay. Indie freedom lets you focus on the soul of the game.

4. The “Lightning in a Bottle” Mechanics

Design the core loop around three pillars:

1. **Low skill floor.** Anyone can pick it up, understand how to move and interact, and immediately have fun.
2. **High skill ceiling.** Deep systems beneath the surface (like Redstone or advanced building) that dedicated players spend years mastering.
3. **Infinitely expandable but “homey.”** The world can grow endlessly yet still feel cozy, comforting, and personal.

THIS IS THE MOST IMPORTANT SECTION. Low floor / high ceiling maps PERFECTLY onto puzzle games. A bilging puzzle anyone can play in 10 seconds, but with depth (combos, timing, optimization) that masters chase for years — that is the lightning. Build every parlor game this way.

5. Honest Fit Analysis — Read This

Not all of the video’s advice fits a structured puzzle-adventure. Feeding Claude Code contradictory rules would hurt the project, so here is what to keep, adapt, or ignore:

VIDEO PRINCIPLE	FIT?	HOW IT APPLIES TO SHIVALIVA SHANTY
Memorable music	KEEP	Perfect fit. Per-island themes + shanties are core identity. High priority.
Simplicity / easy core	KEEP	Perfect fit. Each parlor game readable in seconds; clean core loop.
Low floor / high ceiling	KEEP	The single best lesson here. Build every puzzle this way — trivial to start, deep to master.
Affordable, accessible	KEEP	Aligns with the Community Research doc: one-time price, no pay-to-win, family-friendly.
Not story-driven / replayable	ADAPT	Shivaliva is puzzle-skill-first with a light progression frame (jobs, voyages, ship ownership). Lean into that: the puzzles + mastery ladder + co-op are the infinitely-replayable long tail. Any narrative is a thin wrapper, never a linear corridor that ends.
Indie soul over monetization	KEEP	Already locked. You are indie; lean into it.
Below-Teen rating	ADAPT	Aim family-friendly, but brigand encounters and boarding fights (the voyage loop) mean mild conflict. Keep violence cartoonish and bloodless to stay broadly accessible.
Unconstrained sandbox creativity	IGNORE	Direct conflict. Shivaliva is a structured puzzle-skill game (job loops, voyages, mastery ladder), NOT a sandbox. Do NOT bolt on free-build sandbox systems — it would dilute the focused design and balloon scope. Borrow the FEELING of player expression (cosmetics, ship customization, optional

VIDEO PRINCIPLE	FIT?	HOW IT APPLIES TO SHIVALIVA SHANTY
		goals, mastery chasing), not the open-world mechanic.

6. Working Checklist

Pin these questions. Revisit them every time a new system is added:

- ☐ Can a child understand the core mechanic of any parlor game within 5 minutes?
- ☐ Is the audio / music memorable enough to trigger emotional nostalgia years later?
- ☐ Do players have meaningful self-directed goals (cosmetics, ship pride, mastery ranks, co-op) — not just the job-and-voyage path?
- ☐ Does every puzzle have a genuinely low floor AND a genuinely high ceiling?
- ☐ Is the world “homey” — does Cradle Rock and the player’s ship feel like a place to return to?
- ☐ Am I keeping it simple, or bolting on systems before the core is proven fun?

The One Line

Low floor. High ceiling. Music you remember. A world that feels like home. Built simple, by one person who cares.

Source: “We Need A New Minecraft” — Internet Intellectuals (YouTube)